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THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

with 1,000+ videos. Among them, Being Chhattisgarhiya, the first Chhattisgarhi comedy YouTube channel, has a library of 250+ videos and boasts of 120,000+ subscribers. Says co-founder Jai Verma, "Humour is at the core of our channel, but the messaging is towards preserving Chhattisgarhi festivals and culture."

So, when and how did all of this begin? In 2016, when Jai and his friend Gyanendra Shukla, both residents of Tulsi, decided to set up a YouTube channel. "I had worked as a network engineer while Jai was a teacher," says Gyanendra. "We thought of creating content and posting it on YouTube for fun. But we didn't know how to edit videos, and also ran into a lot of copyright issues." It was only after their several videos were pulled down that the two came to understand the technicalities involved, and thus was born Being Chhattisgarhiya in 2018.

As the channel gained popularity and brought in handsome earnings for its creators, others in the village were also motivated to grab a piece of the pie. But there is a code they all adhere to. That is, to create only 'family-friendly' content. Rooted in culture, most of the videos are contemporary. So, if the election season in Chhattisgarh inspired Tulsi's content creators in recent months, videos on Cher Chera—a harvest festival that falls in January—are being shot nowadays, among other themes. "The idea is to preserve our local culture," says Gyanendra. "Unless we get the elders to talk about how festivals were celebrated in the past, how will the youth be able to carry on the tradition?"

Of the 40-odd channels, Aditya Baghel's Back Benchers Creation (24,800+ subscribers), Nimga Chhattisgadhiya (9,200+), music channel Gold CG04 (6,400+) and Fun Tapri (3,000+) are gaining popularity in the state's central belt. Most of the content creators work in a collaborative, yet a decentralised, manner. Whoever has an idea discusses it with the others, taking suggestions on every aspect, be it the script, acting or camera work. Once the script is ready, actors best suited to play the part are identified. Most of those selected initially were from Ramlila *mandlis* that are quite active in the village. But now, a new generation of performers has spawned in the village, some of whom have gained fame and work beyond its boundaries too. Pinky Sahu, for instance, who is now working in Chhattisgarhi movies.

Most channels earn around Rs 20,000-40,000 per month, paid by YouTube based on their views. Some YouTubers have also signed contracts to shoot small-scale ad films while others endorse products in their videos, getting paid in return. But more importantly these YouTube channels, say locals, have helped steer the village youth in a positive direction, away from vices. ■

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Gyanendra Shukla, *Co-founder, Being Chhattisgarhiya*

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **With 40 active YouTube channels, content creators from Tulsi are taking Chhattisgarhi culture to a wider audience**
- **Together, they have uploaded 1,000+ videos. Most channels earn Rs 20,000-40,000 per month**
- **The most popular channel—Being Chhattisgarhiya—alone has a library of 250+ videos and boasts of 122,000+ subscribers**

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